

Aaron — The Improvement Brief

The reading version. Everything here is measured from your own takes — 100+ recordings scored note-by-note against 50 professional reference vocals. No opinion, no guesswork.

The whole brief in four sentences.
Your landings are already professional — now clean up the *approach*: see it, land it, stay on it.
Live lighter on the gear change you stand on all night.
Keep the ribs wide to the last word, and keep held notes still before you shape them.
When the lights are on: one gear in reserve — the microphone does the loudness.

1. Where you actually are

You are measurably good — not "good for karaoke", good against professionals. The instrument is already there; what's left is aim.

Strength	Measured	Meaning
Landing accuracy	20–25 cents from centre	Pro-level, and stable since 2019 — don't spend practice on it
Range	A2 – E5 (~2.5 octaves)	Full functional range; falsetto ceiling E5
"Money zone"	B3 – B4	Where your voice reads genuinely world-class
Under pressure	9.3 capture-fair at Brighton	Sung <i>blind</i> — backing so loud you couldn't hear yourself

(Capture-fair scale: 10 = a typical professional. That 9.3 was a live take with zero self-monitoring.)

Everything below sits on top of that. There are only three things to fix: the way you **start** notes, the way you **hold** them, and the way you **finish** phrases.

2. The three gaps

Gap	You	Reference	The verdict
Approach — clean note entries	23.7% (16th percentile)	Pro median 33.2%; Farnham 57.1%	Biggest gap. Your landing is fine; your approach isn't
Hold — drift inside a held note	39.8 cents	Farnham 15 cents	What listeners feel most
Finish — phrase endings that sag	51.5%	Farnham 28.6–29.7%	Support released early, not lack of air

2a. Approach — the single highest-value fix

Only ~1 entry in 4 starts clean on the note. Out of 50 pro references, **42 start their notes more cleanly** than your typical take. What happens instead: you slide *up* into ~48% of notes from nearly a semitone below, and *overshoot* the top on ~29%. The ear hears all of that as loose pitch — even though the note you finally sit on is

dead centre. The engine scores where you land; the room hears how you got there.

Scooping isn't the flaw. Farnham scoops from nearly the same depth you do — he just does it **3× less often, by choice**. Make the clean entry your default, then put the scoop back where you *want* it. That's style instead of habit.

Cue: see it, land it, stay on it. Hear the note in your head before you make a sound. A voice scoops when it's *searching*; take away the search, take away the scoop.

2b. You live on your passaggio

Fact	Value
Most-used note	E4
Working range on stage	~A3 – F#4
Gear change (passaggio)	D4 – E4

The note you sing most is the note your voice changes gear on. That's why full nights feel taxing — it's geography, not weakness. So *passaggio* work is **maintenance on your most-used range**, not an advanced extra.

The answer is already in your technique: the engine measured Farnham's original *Pressure Down* vocal at **~76% light production** — not heavy chest. The man who owns the song treats those exact notes as *lifted speech*. Your lighter upper setup is the correct professional answer, confirmed by the master. When the chorus sits on C#4/D4/E4 — think mix, think lifted speech, let the mic do the loudness.

2c. The honest breath story

Your median phrase is **under 3 seconds** — nobody runs out of air in 3 seconds. This is **not** a lung-capacity problem; you let go of the support before the phrase finishes. Some flagged "sags" are also just deliberate rock fall-offs the originals make too (*Livin' on a Prayer*, *Let's Stay Together*). But two songs are genuinely your weakest and are parked out of the ladder:

Song	Sagging endings	vs your own mean (51.6%)
Bye Bye Love	75.5%	+23.9
You Sexy Thing	66.6%	+15.0
Pressure Down	50.6%	−1.0 (fine)
My Babe	48.5%	−3.1 (fine)

The fix — the Farinelli breath (silent, safe any day): in 4, suspend 4, out 4. The whole exercise is the suspension — and the classic error is holding it in the wrong place. **The hold is your ribs staying wide, not your throat closing.** Test: hum straight out of the suspension; a click/catch/push means you held it at the glottis — reset and hold it at the ribs. On stage it compresses to three words: **last word loud**.

2d. Held notes that wander

A held note of yours drifts ~40 cents; Farnham's move ~15. Two drills:

- **Straight tone against a drone** — 8–10 s, dead straight, no vibrato, no swell. Drift is invisible alone, obvious against a reference pitch.
- **Messa di voce** — soft → full → soft on one breath, pitch unmoving.

Rule: still first, shape second. If the straight tone isn't solid today, don't add the swell today. And it's already working: Kung Fu Fighting drift fell **41.6 → 31.2 cents in a single night** (Brighton). Pro median is ~24.

3. The 20-minute daily programme

5–6 days a week, **not 7** — the rest day is when the adaptation lands. (15-minute version = blocks 0, 1, 2, 3. **Never cut block 0.**)

#	Block	Min	Moves this number
0	SOVTE wake-up (straw/water, glides)	3	Prepares everything, costs nothing — <i>never skip</i>
1	Farinelli breath — silent	3	Sag 51.5% → under 35%
2	Onset planting (the biggest gap)	5	Clean entries 23.7% → 33%+
3	Sustain → Messa di voce	4	Drift 39.8c → under 25c
4	Passaggio & range	3	Working top; M2 in songs
5	Song application (one phrase)	2	Phrase length 2.7s → 4s+

Block 2 in detail (biggest deficit): (a) one pitch three ways — breathy / hard / balanced — to build the feel; (b) silent-target planting — play a note, stop it, hear it, land it clean, hold 2s, ×10 pitches; (c) deliberate contrast — scoop a known phrase on purpose, then sing it clean, alternate.

Weekly rotation

Same 20 minutes; one block gets a double share each day.

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Onsets (2)	Sustain (3)	Breath (1) — light day	Onsets (2)	Passaggio (4)	Song / gig (5)	Off / recovery

Recovery version (tired/post-gig): blocks 0 + 1 only — 6 minutes, costs the folds almost nothing, keeps the streak. **Deload every 4th week:** halve everything — adaptation lands in the easy week.

4. The campaign — December

The killer in past years was **not skill** — **it was the pressure response** (pushing too hard under nerves). The proof it's beatable: Brighton, no monitoring, best measured live take, by staying inside yourself.

Round	Date	Song	Why
Warm-ups	Oct 7 & 14	(dress rehearsals)	Sing semi candidates live
Heats 1–4	Oct 21 – Nov 11	Kung Fu Fighting	9.3 blind at Brighton; survives bad monitoring
Quarter-finals	Nov 18 & 25	Pressure Down	Signature; drilled 9×
Semi-final	Dec 2	Showpiece A (data decides)	Your historical wall
Grand final	Dec 9	Showpiece B	—

Showpiece decided by data by October: **Reasons** (climbed 7.7 → 8.3 in a week) vs **You're the Voice** (highest ceiling, untested). Backups: Oh What a Night, One.

Two load-bearing rules for the night:

1. **One cue only on stage** — under adrenaline one survives, three don't: *"One gear in reserve — the microphone does the loudness. Let the chorus pull the power out of me."*
2. **There is no song two.** Your accuracy climbs across a set (intonation 6.0 → 7.0 → 10.0 over three songs). In a heat you get one song, cold — so **arrive in song-three condition**: full warm-up at home, singing in the car, quiet sing-along at the venue. Worth more than any drill.

Friday karaoke now has a job: **pressure inoculation**. Score irrelevant; executing "one gear in reserve" with adrenaline in your blood is the whole assignment.

5. The rules that override everything

- **Never train through hoarseness.** Clears overnight = fatigue. Still there after a full rest day = stop sign.
- **Pain is always a stop.** Singing should feel free.
- **Hoarse a week later, or lost top notes that don't return** → a laryngologist who scopes, not wait-and-see.
- **Whisper is worse than quiet speech.** On rest days, speak softly; don't whisper.
- **Don't train two systems to failure at once** — you're mid rib-loading; don't also push the voice to symptoms the same week.
- **Fresh beats drilled**, especially inside 9 weeks of the competition.

6. How you'll know it's working

Don't judge by feel — record **one take of Pressure Down or Reasons a month**, same conditions, and read four raw numbers (always comparable, no caveats):

Number	Today	3-month target
Clean entries	23.7% (16th pct)	33%+ (50th pct)
Sagging endings	51.5%	under 35%
Held-note drift	39.8 cents	under 25 cents
Median phrase length	2.7 s	4 s+

Don't expect the overall /10 to jump even when all four improve — the things you're fixing are weighted lightly in the score, and onsets aren't scored at all. That's a known limitation of the number, not a failure of the work. **The point is to sound better to a room — and to a panel on December 2nd — not to move a number.** The blind listening test already proved your ear tracks these even when the score doesn't.

You're closer than you think. Twenty minutes a day, five days a week, one recorded take a month. Everything else is patience.